The Night-Garden of Dreams

Based on the science of sleep by Matthew Walker

Adapted for Children

The Night-Garden of Dreams

Cast of Characters

• Toby (11 years old) — An inventive sixth-grader who stays up way past midnight tinkering with wooden clockwork soldiers beneath his quilt, convinced that sleeping is a boring waste of perfectly good hours.

• Nyx — The calm, quick-witted Keeper of the Night-Garden, cloaked in starlight, who oversees the bustling midnight crews that keep Toby's mind and body running.

• Pip — A brisk, ink-smudged Archive Weaver (chief among the Dream-Elves) who takes immense pride in sorting daytime memories and strongly dislikes unscheduled midnight delays.

• Sam (11 years old) — Toby's loyal best friend and workshop partner at school, who accidentally catches the explosion of Toby's sleep-starved temper.

Chapter 1: The Midnight Toy

To Toby, nine-thirty at night felt like the greatest scam ever invented by adults.

All day long, his time belonged to someone else: school bells, fractions, chores, setting the supper table, brushing teeth. Only after the house settled into quiet clicks and floorboards creaking did the hours feel completely, gloriously his.

For four nights in a row, as soon as his mother's footsteps faded down the hall, Toby propped a tent of blankets over his knees, slid open the brass shutter on his tiny hooded reading lantern, and pulled out his miniature wooden siege-engine and carved soldiers. Until nearly one in the morning, he adjusted rubber-band tensioners, sketched battle maps in the margins of his notebook, and staged silent tabletop skirmishes.

Everyone else is just lying there doing nothing for nine hours, Toby told himself smugly as the hallway clock chimed twelve-thirty on Wednesday night. If I stay awake two extra hours every night, that's fourteen bonus hours a week. Practically an extra Saturday!

Thursday morning, however, did not feel like a bonus Saturday.

When Toby's alarm rang at seven, his eyelids felt glued shut with tree sap. Inside his skull sat a thick, damp wad of gray wool.

By third-period math, the wool had grown heavier. Mr. Patel wrote five fraction-division problems on the chalkboard—the exact kind Toby had practiced effortlessly on Wednesday afternoon. Toby stared down at his slate. He knew the rule about flipping the second fraction—or wait, did you flip the first one? The numbers seemed to slide sideways like greased marbles. When Mr. Patel called on him, Toby blurted out an answer forty times too large, then dropped his wooden slate with a loud clatter that made two rows giggle.

At recess, things got worse. During courtyard wall-ball, a slow bounce came straight toward Toby's sneakers—a ball he could normally snag one-handed with his eyes half-shut. His

hands moved a fraction of a second too late. The rubber ball glanced off his wrists and rolled into a puddle.

Beside him, his best friend Sam jogged over, laughing good-naturedly, and bumped Toby's elbow the way they did every single day. "Whoa, butterfingers! Want a redo?"

Heat flared behind Toby's eyes like dry straw catching fire. Before his brain could even check whether Sam was teasing meanly—which Sam never did—words exploded out of Toby's mouth.

"Shut up, Sam! At least I didn't botch the whole science chart yesterday like you did!"

Sam's grin vanished as if someone had wiped it off with a sponge. He stepped back, blinked once, and muttered, "Jeez, Toby. Forget it," before walking away toward the swings alone.

Toby stood beside the puddle with his stomach sinking. He hadn't meant it. Not even a little bit. Yet all afternoon he felt too irritable and foggy to apologize properly.

"I'm just having an off day," Toby muttered that night, climbing into bed at ten o'clock. Out of stubborn habit, he reached beneath his pillow for his hooded lantern and wooden catapult. "Five minutes of tinkering will cheer me up."

Except his heavy eyelids drooped once, twice—and instead of darkness, a cool, velvety violet mist rolled quietly across his bedroom floorboards, smelling faintly of pine needles after summer rain and ozone before lightning.

Standing beside the foot of his bed was a tall figure whose dark hair held tiny, drifting constellations, wrapped in a traveler's cloak the exact deep indigo of the sky an hour before midnight.

"Fourteen bonus hours a week," said Nyx dryly, though her luminous silver eyes held a warm spark of amusement. "Interesting math, Toby. Come along. Before you fire your night crew completely, you ought to see what happens where the hours go."

Chapter 2: The Library of the Mind

Toby stepped out of his blankets onto a pathway of cool silver moss—and gasped.

Stretching in every direction beneath twin moons lay an immense, terraced botanical metropolis known as the Night-Garden. Lanterns grew on curving vines. Crystal aqueducts hummed overhead. And everywhere Toby looked, thousands upon thousands of knee-high Dream-Elves in rolled-up Indigo sleeves were sprinting, sweeping, hammering, and hoisting glowing parcels like stagehands between acts of a giant play—except right now, half of them were standing around leaning on their brooms, checking pocket watches in frustration.

"Why are they waiting?" Toby asked.

"Because the building owner refused to lock the front doors until quarter past midnight three nights running," came a crisp voice.

A small, sharp-eared Weaver wearing brass-rimmed spectacles and three ink pens behind his ear marched up to them, clutching a clipboard thicker than his own chest.

"Nyx, tell him!" said Pip, gesturing indignantly toward a colossal pavilion behind them. "We had an eight-hour cleaning and filing shift scheduled, and he left us five and a half! Do you have any idea what five and a half hours does to the Glass Inbox?"

Nyx led Toby inside the pavilion. Right near the entrance stood a fragile, shimmering table of clear glass piled precariously high with thousands of glowing paper slips—every conversation, fraction rule, bird song, joke, and catapult measurement Toby had noticed over the past two days. Several stacks were leaning dangerously over the edge; a whole bundle labeled WEDNESDAY FRACTIONS had already slid onto the floor and faded to blank white paper.

Beyond the Glass Table towered magnificent halls of ancient oak bookshelves stretching out of sight.

"Meet the Library of your Mind," Nyx explained. "While you are awake, every new fact and skill you practice lands temporarily on this small Glass Table. It holds plenty for one day, not three. Only when you enter deep, quiet sleep can Pip's couriers carry today's glowing pages across the bridges and carve them permanently into the Oak Vaults—clearing the Glass Table clean for tomorrow morning."

Toby stared at the faded blank slips on the floor. "Wait. That's why my brain went totally blank when Mr. Patel called on me today? I did study those fractions!"

"You put them on the Glass Table," Pip corrected briskly, tapping his clipboard. "Then you kept the lights blazing with wooden soldiers so my couriers couldn't lock them into the Oak Shelves! Oh, and look at the bridges!"

Toby looked down at the stone pathways connecting the shelves. Everywhere, ankle-deep drifts of fine, heavy Grey Sand clogged the walkways, slowing every runner to a crawl. Elves with wide push-brooms were furiously sweeping the Grey Sand into sluice channels where clear silver water washed it away.

"What is all that dust?" Toby asked.

"Wakefulness Sand," said Nyx, crouching to let a handful trickle heavily through her fingers. "From the second you open your eyes at seven in the morning, every single thought you think drops grains of this Grey Sand along your brain's pathways. By nine-thirty at night, the sand is meant to feel heavy enough to nudge you gently into bed so our floodgates can wash the streets spotless. When you fight past it until one in the morning, tomorrow begins with yesterday's sand still ankle-deep in the halls."

Further up in the high balconies, another team of weavers was stringing shimmering threads between completely different shelves—connecting a memory of a bent willow branch Toby had seen by the creek last summer to the jammed lever on his wooden catapult.

"Dream-weavers," Nyx smiled when she saw Toby staring upward. "During the late-night dream shifts, they test wild combinations between old ideas and new problems. Half of human invention happens while the inventor's head is on a pillow."

Chapter 3: The Repair Shop

Leaving Pip barking cheerful orders as the sweepers cleared Passage Four, Nyx guided Toby down a cedar-lined terrace into a warm, glowing conservatory that smelled of crushed mint and clean pine resin.

In the center of a mossy amphitheater rested a life-sized, translucent sculpture shaped exactly like eleven-year-old Toby—woven from thousands of golden muscle fibers, ivory bone-beams, and flashing silver nerve-wires.

Swarming gently over the figure were hundreds of artisan Dream-Elves carrying miniature golden mallets, spools of silk cable, and vials of pearl-white mortar.

Near the knees and shoulders, tiny masons were carefully laying microscopic rings of fresh ivory along the ends of the bones, lengthening the frame millimeter by millimeter. Further up, cable-smiths wrapped fresh insulation around a frayed silver wire connecting the figure's eyes to its wrists.

"Hold on," Toby said, stepping closer in amazement. "Are they making me taller right now?"

"When else did you think you grew—during social studies?" Nyx asked with a sideways grin. "Your deepest early-night sleep is when the master builders release growth mortar, mend tiny tears in your muscles from running at recess, and train millions of microscopic shield-guards to fight off winter colds."

Toby pointed to the frayed silver wire between the sculpture's eyes and hands, where two elves were shaking their heads over a scorched patch left unfinished from the night before. "What's that wire?"

"Reaction timing," Nyx said gently. "It fires signals from your eyes to your fingers in less than a blink—assuming the insulation gets rewrapped overnight. Skip two hours of sleep, and that signal travels just a fraction of a second slower. Not enough for you to notice sitting in a

chair... right until a rubber ball bounces toward your wrists in the schoolyard."

Toby winced, looking down at his real hands. Yesterday he had blamed "bad luck" and his sneakers. Meanwhile, his exhausted repair crew had barely been given enough time to unpack their toolboxes.

"You treat your body and brain like an enemy camp you have to sneak past at bedtime," Nyx observed—without scolding, simply stating a fact the way a master mechanic points out a dry engine. "In reality, every single elf in this conservatory works exclusively for you."

Chapter 4: The Emotional Stream

From the conservatory, the sound of rushing water drew Toby toward the heart of the Night-Garden.

Here, between banks of luminescent blue ferns, flowed a wide river. Upstream, where today's memories tumbled down a rocky chute into the basin, the water churned muddy, hot, and tangled with thorny red briars. Perched on a stone tower right beside the rapids hung a massive crimson Alarm Bell, humming nervously and twitching at every tiny splash—even when a harmless leaf landed on the water.

Downstream, however, where a warm, star-lit mist hovered over deep pools, Dream-Elves in small wooden skiffs skimmed the thorns away, letting clean, calm indigo water glide smoothly toward the dawn gates.

"This," Nyx said softly, "is the Emotional Stream—and up on that tower sits your Watchtower Bell. Its job during the daytime is to keep you safe from real threats. The trouble is, when you cut off your late-morning dream sleep—the deepest hours right before sunrise—nobody cools the Watchtower Bell down."

Toby watched a harmless cedar cone drop into the unwashed rapids upstream. Instantly, the crimson Bell CLANGED as if a bear had charged into the garden.

In the swirling, muddy water right beneath the tower, a glowing reflection flickered to life. Toby saw the schoolyard puddle. He saw Sam jogging over with an open, friendly grin, bumping his elbow: "Whoa, butterfingers! Want a redo?" And he saw his own red-faced reflection barking cruel words about Sam's science chart while the crimson Watchtower Bell overhead hammered wildly out of control.

Toby swallowed hard, looking away from the water. "I didn't even mean to say that to Sam. It felt like somebody turned the volume knob on my annoyance up to ten before I could think."

"That is literally what happens," Nyx said, resting a light, cool hand on Toby's shoulder. "Dream-waters act like overnight balm for the heart. Our skiff crews take the prickly, embarrassing, frustrating moments of your day and gently soak them until the stinging heat washes downstream—leaving you the lesson without the raw burn. Without enough sleep, the mud stays in the water and the Bell rings at friendly elbows as if they were attacks."

Toby watched two skiff-elves carefully lift the thorny memory of fourth-period courtyard ball into the warm indigo mist downstream. Slowly, the jagged red briars around Sam's face dissolved, leaving behind a clear, honest truth floating calmly on the surface: Sam wasn't laughing at me; he was trying to make me feel better. And tomorrow I want to make it right.

"How much longer until seven o'clock?" Toby asked quietly.

Nyx checked the stars wheeling overhead. "Nearly eight full hours—time inside the Night-Garden moves generously once you stop fighting the gates. If you blow out your lantern for real, Pip's vault crews, the cable-smiths, and the river skiffs can still finish the whole shift."

Toby didn't hesitate. "Show me the way back to my pillow."

Chapter 5: Waking Up Fresh

Sunlight—crisp, pale gold October sunlight—spilled across Toby's quilt when he opened his eyes.

For three seconds he lay completely still, waiting for the familiar wad of damp gray wool inside his skull.

It wasn't there. His head felt light, spacious, and weirdly quiet, like a room after someone opens all the windows on a breezy morning. Even before his alarm clock clicked to seven, he swung his legs onto the rug without groaning once.

While tying his sneakers on the back steps, an idea popped effortlessly into his head—clear as a bell: If I carve the catapult's release notch at an angle like that bent willow branch by the creek, the lever won't jam at all! Somewhere up in the high oak balconies last night, Pip's dream-weavers had clearly worked overtime.

The first thing Toby did when he reached the schoolyard gate was walk straight over to the bike racks where Sam was unlocking his chain. Toby's stomach gave a small nervous flip, though today his Watchtower Bell stayed calm and quiet.

"Hey, Sam," Toby said plainly, holding out a tiny carved wooden shield he had brought from his desk. "What I said yesterday about your science chart was totally unfair. I stayed up super late all week messing around with a lantern, my brain was fried, and I took it out on you. I'm really sorry."

Sam looked at the little wooden shield, then up at Toby's face, testing to make sure it was real. After two seconds, the familiar crooked grin broke across Sam's freckles.

"Apology accepted," Sam said, pocketing the shield. "Though seriously, you looked like an angry raccoon yesterday. Did you finally sleep?"

"Nine hours," Toby grinned. "Wait till recess—my hands actually work today."

He wasn't exaggerating. In third-period math, when Mr. Patel wrote mixed fractions on the board, the steps stepped neatly off the Oak Shelves right onto Toby's slate without a single slip. At recess, he snagged two wicked corner bounces in wall-ball and laughed louder than anyone when he missed the third.

That evening, at nine o'clock, Toby tested his angled willow-notch design on his wooden catapult—watching it launch a cork cleanly across his rug on the very first try—and then, at nine-fifteen sharp, packed the catapult and soldiers neatly into their wooden chest.

He didn't feel cheated out of "bonus hours" anymore. Blowing out the candle beside his bed and sliding his hooded lantern onto the high shelf, Toby pulled the warm quilt up to his chin and listened to the house settle into darkness.

"Front doors are locked, Pip," Toby whispered with a quiet smile as his eyes drifted shut. "All yours, Night-Shift."

Real-Life Bridge for 11-Year-Olds

When you turn eleven or twelve, staying up late starts feeling like freedom. Whether it is reading under the covers, tinkering with projects, chatting, or scrolling on a screen, your brain can easily trick you into thinking sleep is "dead time" where nothing happens—as if going to bed early means missing out.

Neuroscientists who study eleven-year-old brains discovered that the exact opposite is true. Your brain is actually more active in certain ways at night than during school, running four irreplaceable superpowers that only work while you sleep:

• Saving Your Work (The Glass Table to Oak Vaults): Studying math, Spanish vocabulary, or a new guitar chord puts that information onto a temporary "USB stick" in your brain (the hippocampus). Deep sleep physically transfers those files into permanent storage (the cortex) and deletes clutter so you have room to learn tomorrow.

• Upgrading Sports and Gaming Reflexes (The Repair Shop): Physical growth spurts happen mostly during deep sleep! Even cooler, your brain replays physical movements—free throws, piano fingerings, skateboard balance, dance steps—at high speed overnight, wiring muscle memory so what felt clumsy on Tuesday feels smooth on Wednesday.

• Turning Down the Drama Alarm (The Emotional Stream): Scientists found that skipping just two hours of sleep makes the brain's emotional alarm center (the amygdala) up to sixty percent more reactive the next day! That is why a harmless joke from a friend or an annoying request from a parent can suddenly make you want to snap or cry when you are tired.

• Beating the Fake-Noon Trap: Bright overhead lights and glowing screens right before bed beam blue wavelengths into your eyes that tell your brain's master clock, "Hey, it's twelve noon! Keep the Night-Garden gates locked!" Dimming lights and switching to calm, screen-free wind-down thirty minutes before sleep gives Nyx's crews the green light on time.

Discussion Prompts

• Have you ever had a "fuzzy wool" day like Toby's Thursday, where a tiny annoyance—like a bumped elbow or a small teasing comment—suddenly felt ten times bigger than usual? Looking back, how much had you slept the night before?

• Why does staying up late often feel like winning "bonus free time" in the moment, and how does knowing about Pip's Glass Table and the Repair Shop change how you view those midnight hours?

• Think of a physical skill or tricky school topic that felt frustrating one day, then weirdly clicked better after a good night's sleep. What were your Dream-Weavers and cable-smiths doing overnight?

• If you designed your own thirty-minute "Gates Open" wind-down routine before sleep—one that actually feels relaxing rather than like a punishment—what three things would you put in it?